UDAIPUR

The City of Lakes, as Udaipur is called, is set in a lush, green part of Rajasthan. Its fairy tale palaces and gardens are drenched in romance while its temples and holy places stir the soul. The land of Maharana Pratap, Udaipur is the jewel of Mewar, a kingdom ruled by the Sisodia dynasty for 1,200 years. Legend has it that while Maharana Udai Singh II was out hunting he met a holy man meditating on a hill overlooking Lake Pichhola who advised him to build his palace there. That's how Udaipur was founded and the magnificent City Palace overlooks Lake Pichhola to this day.

The City Palace, of course, is one of Udaipur's biggest attractions. A vast collection of courtyards, pavilions, terraces, corridors, roomns and hanging gardens, the City Palace is approached through a triple-arched gate, the Tripolia, which has eight marble porticoes. The museum here is a must visit.

Built in 1651 by Maharana Jagat Singh, the Indo-Aryan Jagdish Temple is the largest and most beautiful temple in Udaipur, noted for its sculpted images. Saheliyon ki Bari is a small ornamental garden once popular with the ladies of the royal household. In the middle of Lake Pichhola are the Lake Palace and Jagmandir. Other attractions in Udaipur include Ahar Museum, Fateh Sagar Lake, Bagore ki Haveli, Shilpgram, Wax Museum and Crystal Gallery.

the afflicted subjects and is said to be one of the largest private residences in the world. Jaswant Thada is a royal cenotaph in white marble built in 1899 in memory of Maharaja Jaswant Singh II. The Sardar Government Musuem has an exquisite ensemble of paintings, sculptures and antique weapons. Girdikot and Sardar Market are colourful markets with tiny shops dotting the narrow lanes of Jodhpur and offer a variety of interesting handicrafts. Other attractions include Khejarla Fort, Chamunda Mataji Temple, Ranisar-Padamsar twin lakes within Mehrangarh Fort, Ghanta Ghar, Sardar Samand Lake and Palace, Balsamand Lake, Guda Village, etc. You can also make excursions to Kheechan, which is a birding hotspot, and Mandore Gardens which being the ancient capital of Marwar has the cenotaphs of Jodhpur's rulers.

Jaisalmer

Rising like a gold confection in the middle of the desert, this citadel in yellow sandstone is a site to behold. Today, this living fort is an atmospheric tourist destination with its narrow lanes, charming cafés, and architecturally stunning temples and palaces.

The 20th- century Umaid Bhawan Palace was built as a famine relief project to provide employment to the afflicted subjects and is said to be one of the largest private residences in the world.

A few merchant havelis in Jaisalmer are worth seeing. These include Nathmalji ki Haveli, noted for the splendid miniature paintings on its interior walls and the Patwon ki Haveli, an elaborate affair featuring exquisitely carved pillars and extensive corridors and chambers.

The Jaisalmer War Museum is the first war museum in the country to have a sound and light show. Gadisar Lake is a stunning waterbody fed by rain which attracts a lot of avian visitors. It also hosts a spectacular laser water show.

Sam Sand Dunes lie 42 kilometres from Jaisalmer and no trip here is complete without visiting them for the camel rides on the rippling dunes and to watch the sun set over the Thar Desert. The Desert Festival, which takes place in February every year, is a great time to visit Jaisalmer.

City Palace, Udaipur